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Culturally sustaining disciplinary language and literacy instruction for Hmong-American children

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ABSTRACT

Among the many approaches proposed for closing opportunity and achievement gaps is supporting student's academic language development. Often, however, instructional approaches that are more familiar to teachers, such as helping students learn new vocabulary, are prioritized over more complex and less familiar explorations into disciplinary language, such as analyzing how a whole text is organized or identifying grammatical boundaries within sentences and connecting these analyses to disciplinary learning goals. In addition, the cultural and linguistic assets students bring to the classroom, valuable resources for learning, are often neglected in school, depriving students an opportunity to leverage and expand such resources. This article argues for an instructional approach that integrates disciplinary language and literacy teaching with culturally sustaining pedagogy. We synthesize research and theories on the approach and provide illustrative examples with elementary grades Hmong-American children.

In this article, we share an approach for supporting students' disciplinary language and literacy development in culturally sustaining, intellectually rich ways. We begin with the premise that classrooms must be communities that honor students' multiple intersecting identities, promote cultural and linguistic pluralism, foster students' sense of belonging and connectedness to one another and to their teachers, challenge thinking, and cultivate autonomy and agency. Autonomy and agency require the development of deep and broad competence with language and literacy so that students can fully engage in grade level academic content learning, successfully progress through the grades, graduate from high school, and have the greatest number of options for college, careers, and a fulfilling life. Deep and broad competence requires much more than basic reading comprehension and writing skills. It involves advanced disciplinary language and literacy, including the ability to interpret and critique complex texts and concepts from a disciplinary perspective and express ideas in ways that meet the norms and expectations of the discipline.

Academic language, broadly defined

Academic language has been an important concept in understanding advanced language competencies and the complexity of language development. The construct has been described as the type of language necessary for school success and as lexically dense,

syntactically complex, technical, concise, formal, abstract, and discipline-specific (Uccelli & Phillips Galloway, 2018). The concept has been instrumental in raising awareness about language itself and how language functions in various situations and contexts.

However, the term academic language also has its limitations. Definitions vary based on the theoretical traditions in which they are grounded. Short and concise definitions are problematic since advanced language competencies reflect disciplinary thinking and practices that are not easily generalized. Perhaps because of these challenges, for some, academic language seems to be synonymous with sophisticated vocabulary, complex syntax, complete sentences, and so-called *proper* or *correct* uses of language. This limited notion of academic language can inhibit students' advanced content and language development, damage their morale, and obstruct academic success (Dudley-Marline & Lucas, 2009).

For example, if students perceive that there are *correct* and *incorrect* ways of using language in school, they may feel marginalized and that there is no place for the rich linguistic assets they bring from their homes and communities. By focusing on *correctness*, students may not be attentive to the myriad language choices skilled authors make to craft their texts with an intended purpose: intentional choices students themselves could make in their own writing. Multilingual and multidialectal students have complex linguistic repertoires, valuable assets for school learning. Often, these resources are not recognized as such, and students miss the empowering opportunity to leverage and expand them (García, Johnson, & Seltzer, 2017). When students are prohibited from freely using their full reservoir of language resources, their opportunities to express their ideas, develop new language competencies and conceptual understandings, and learn from and with their peers are hindered.

There is also a perception that some ethnically diverse students, particularly those with immigrant backgrounds, are incapable of successfully engaging with the academic language in complex texts (Olvera, 2015). As a result, some students are given below-grade-level texts, limiting their access to the complex disciplinary concepts and language that are embedded in them (Menken & Kleyn, 2010).

Disciplinary language and literacy

We use the term *disciplinary language and literacy* to refer to the specialized ways of making meaning with and communicating about subject matter within each school discipline. Each discipline has its own means of knowledge construction, specialized language, and expectations for using language (Schleppegrell, 2004). These distinctions include how reading is approached, how inquiry is done, and norms for conversations and writing (Lee, 2017). For instance, while some writing norms are common across disciplines, such as the expectation to connect claims, evidence, and reasoning in an argument, each discipline has its own unique norms, such as what counts as evidence, what constitutes reasoning, and what language is valued when linking claims, evidence, and reasoning.

Our perspective on disciplinary language and literacy is informed by Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL), a theory of language first developed by Michael Halliday (1925–2018) and expanded internationally in a range of disciplines, including science,

history, language arts, and mathematics (see, for example, Coffin, 2010; Moore & Schleppegrell, 2014). Some key applications of the theory for education are:

- *Language is a meaning making resource that is functional for its context.* Students can learn to make deliberate and purpose-driven choices with language to effectively communicate with specific audiences in particular contexts.
- *Language awareness supports content learning.* Understanding how language works in different contexts supports students to read critically and communicate with intentionality and agency.

To make these notions more concrete, we focus on the concepts of *genre*, *register*, and *metalanguage*. **Genres** are “goal-oriented social practices that have evolved in our culture to enable us to get things done” (Derewianka & Jones, 2016, p. 8). For example, broadly speaking, a written argument has the goal of persuading people to think a certain way or do something, and people have general expectations for what arguments contain and how they are presented. A focus on genre can help students identify how authors in different disciplines intentionally organize and use language to craft their arguments and how an argument is different from other text types, such as an explanation or a story. **Register** choices are how genres are realized. They are made according to the content area and topic at hand (for example, using technical vocabulary or figurative language), the roles and relationships of the people interacting (for example, writing to job-alike peers versus people who know little about a topic), and the mode of communication (for example, choosing language typical of oral, written, or multimodal texts). **Metalanguage** is language about language itself, such as “long noun group” or “metaphor.” It gives students the ability to talk about the language in texts and how it is functional for achieving the author’s purpose. Metalanguage helps to demystify language as it empowers students with the words to identify and discuss it. Children as young as the primary grades can use metalanguage that is meaningful to them.

Focusing on genre, register, and metalanguage helps students notice how language shapes meaning. For example, if students are aware of how a typical science explanation is organized, they can pause after each logically-organized section of the text to reflect on its meaning. Instead of skipping over grammatically challenging sentences, such as those containing long noun groups (e.g., *worsening environmental degradation caused by human activities*), students can learn to notice and dwell on grammatical boundaries, which allows them to disentangle the meanings that are packed into them and connect these meanings to disciplinary learning goals.

Culturally sustaining pedagogy

Culturally sustaining pedagogy, which seeks to “perpetuate and foster – to sustain – linguistic, literate, and cultural pluralism as part of schooling for positive social transformation” (Paris & Alim, 2017, p. 1), must be prioritized for students’ disciplinary language and literacy development to flourish. In a culturally sustaining learning environment, students’ home and community knowledge, experiences, perspectives, world views, and learning approaches are valued, affirmed, leveraged, and sustained to make learning more relevant to and effective for them (Aronson & Laughter, 2016; Gay, 2013;

Ladson-Billings, 2014). Culturally sustaining pedagogy is central to a broader assets-oriented framework that views students of color, students with immigrant backgrounds, and students from under-resourced communities as bringing strengths from their home cultures, languages, and communities that must be recognized and prioritized in school learning.

Conversely, a deficits-oriented framework, which predominates in US school systems, views these groups of students as lacking something, needing something, or having problems that need to be fixed. As Paris and Alim (2017) emphasize, the policies, instructional materials, and educator practices that result from a deficits orientation – such as English-only policies or instructional materials that privilege White middle-class norms – are not geared toward sustaining culturally and linguistically diverse students' languages, literacy practices, and cultures. In order to achieve in school, culturally diverse students are asked to abandon their languages and cultures and replace them with monolingualism and conformity to the dominant culture.

Educators working from an assets orientation view academic achievement in relation to broader social realities. They understand that students have been marginalized through systemic and structural inequalities because of their language, ethnicity, race, immigrant background, and economic status, as well as other aspects of their multilayered and intersecting identities, and that we live in a society where specific groups of people are afforded privileges that are denied other groups. In an assets-oriented framework, instructional and leadership practices are responsive to students' histories, current realities, and struggles.

Culturally sustaining practices enact an assets orientation by integrating students' languages, literatures, histories, and cultural ways of learning into the daily curriculum in all disciplines, focusing in particular on providing accurate and positive depictions and counter-narratives to damaging and pervasive negative stereotypes in broader society. They are designed to promote students' cultural pride and sense of belonging in school and to cultivate the potential that each student brings to the classroom. They are open to contributions by students and their families and communities. Culturally sustaining practices focus on social justice for all people, and they foster students' awareness of social injustices and their ability to critique and redress them.

Teachers must see themselves as playing a critical role both in students' healthy identity development and in students' disciplinary language and literacy development so that students have the opportunity to participate in an ever-greater range of school and life learning contexts (Delpit, 2006). If students do not have the opportunity to develop academically in culturally sustaining contexts, they will be ill-equipped to succeed in a school system that marginalizes them and ill-prepared to dismantle and eradicate oppressive systems. In the next section, we share how we approach uniting these theories of disciplinary language and literacy with culturally sustaining teaching in a school serving Hmong-American students.

Theory into practice

"We have a lot of stories written by Hmong authors, so now we have more scholarly written Hmong children's books for Hmong kids and any child who wants to learn Hmong." (Pao Vue, a pseudonym, Hmong-American Kindergarten teacher).

For this article, we draw from experiences at Kashoua Yang School (KYS, a pseudonym), a public elementary school in Sacramento, California. KYS has both a Hmong-English Dual Immersion program, serving just over half of the school's students, and an English language elementary program. The majority of the school's 360 students (about 67%) are Hmong-American, about 18% are Latinx, about 7% are Black/African-American, and the remaining students are white or other ethnicities. More than half of all students in the school are designated as English learners (ELs), most of whom are Hmong-American (all born in the United States). The school's principal and most teachers in both programs are Hmong-Americans who are bilingual and biliterate in Hmong and English. The goal for children in the Hmong Dual Immersion program is for students to become bilingual and biliterate in both Hmong and English. The vision for all children is for students to claim, learn more deeply about, and maintain pride in their rich cultural heritage.

Most of today's elementary age Hmong-American students were born in the United States, often to parents who were also born in the United States. Their grandparents were, for the most part, political refugees from war-torn Southeast Asia. Today, California is home to the largest Hmong population in the US, with a population of close to 95,000 concentrated in the Central Valley, primarily in the agricultural regions of Sacramento and Fresno. Hmong-American students in California are more likely to be living in poverty than other Asian American students, and just 13% of Hmong-origin adults have a bachelors' degree or higher (Valliani, 2015).

In recognition of the need to close persistent academic opportunity gaps for all students at KYS and ensure students are well-prepared for the rigors of middle school, the school's teachers voted to participate in a two-year researcher-practitioner partnership between WestEd (Spycher) and the school district (Girard and Moua). The partnership focused on improving teaching and learning experiences and academic outcomes for multilingual students. The systemic approach included teachers, instructional coaches, principals, and district leaders. The intensive 2-year long teacher professional learning consisted of 10 full-day sessions and multiple classroom coaching sessions in grade level teams. Professional learning was framed by 2 key principles of instructional practice:

- Culturally sustaining teaching affirms, expands, and empowers student voice.
- Disciplinary language exploration scaffolds students' disciplinary thinking, reading, conversations, and writing.

These principles guided how teachers planned lessons, observed student learning, and refined their teaching practice.

Principle #1: Culturally sustaining teaching affirms, expands, and empowers student voice

Culturally and linguistically sustaining classrooms are spaces where students can be their authentic selves, develop a sense of personal empowerment, and build positive relationships with others while they advance academically. By cultivating the heritage language of Hmong-American students, the Hmong Immersion program at KYS is already positioned to sustain the culture and language of Hmong-American students. For all children, the school prioritizes multilingualism and cultural pluralism.

Exploring cultural traditions is a mainstay of the school curriculum. Sixth graders formally research Hmong New Year and engage in activities such as reading, annotating, analyzing, and discussing multiple articles about the topic. Students work in small groups to craft and present an oral presentation that explains Hmong New Year's traditions, origins, and significance to young people today. Third graders read and discuss the book *My Name Is Yoon*, by Helen Recorvits (2014), a story about a child who is a Korean immigrant and her experiences as she struggles to find a sense of belonging in her new American school, as a launching point for an inquiry into their own families' histories. The inquiry involves interviews with family members about their immigration experiences and culminates in formal oral presentations to the class. Descendants of Southeast Asian immigrants may not fully know their families' immigration stories, and this activity is critical for sustaining bonds across generations and ensuring students are knowledgeable about their own histories. For families without recent immigration experiences, the interviews focus on experiences finding a sense of belonging in schools or communities.

This type of activity benefits not only the dominant population of students in the school, Hmong-American students, and other students with recent immigration stories, it includes all students in the school as they research and share about their family backgrounds and learn about those of their peers. Too often, groups of culturally and linguistically diverse students may be overlooked because they comprise a small percentage of the student population, such as the small population of Black/African American students at KYS. By creating activities where all students' histories are studied and shared, all students view themselves as belonging and valued in the school curriculum.

Emphasizing social justice topics, such as investigating local environmental justice issues, raises students' awareness about inequities and supports their understanding that they can raise their voices for positive change. For example, Kindergarten students at KYS learn about the importance of a healthy diet through a unit on community gardens, which includes gardening with Hmong elders, who share their traditional agrarian knowledge. Teachers later integrate the importance of farming in Hmong culture with another science unit about human impact on the environment, focusing on honeybees as a keystone species. During inquiry-based science and literacy activities, students discuss complex science topics and are immersed in disciplinary ideas and language. At the end of the unit, the children author informational books about bees and also letters to the local newspaper to argue for action to address environmental degradation. One child's letter below illustrates how students use their growing disciplinary knowledge and language resources (kindergarten spelling is transposed).

Dear Editor,

We must keep the bees safe and protect (them). Bees are critical because they pollinate fruits and vegetables. Bees are critical because they help us. We should save the bees by not spraying pesticides on crops.

Sincerely,

Fuechy (a pseudonym)

Each grade level includes a unit on human impact on the environment that culminates in such authentic writing tasks, empowering students to have an impact on their world. By linking topics that are culturally and community relevant to students, standards-based

science goals, and disciplinary language and literacy, students are able to have an impact on issues of both local and global importance.

In addition to culturally sustaining topics and texts, in professional learning sessions throughout the partnership, teachers spent time discussing how to recognize implicit bias and their own unconscious use of deficit language or practices, such as only using low level texts with some groups of students or negative words to refer to underperforming students (e.g., *struggling*, *disadvantaged*, *at risk*). Teachers agreed to push back on deficit-oriented classroom practices and policies and intentionally adopt an assets orientation. This part of professional learning took courage, patience, and compassion, and teachers expressed appreciation for safe spaces to take risks and engage in uncomfortable conversations.

Over the course of our collaboration, teachers shared new techniques they were trying out to address implicit and explicit bias and promote positivity and respect. For example, one teacher began to organize class community meetings in which students had an opportunity to discuss issues dealing with charged comments, inequities they observed in the world, or unfair dynamics they perceived in the classroom. In other classrooms, students were invited to collectively craft norms for positive classroom interactions and use protocols for collaborative group work and text-based discussions so that all voices are heard and valued.

Principle #2: Disciplinary language exploration scaffolds students' disciplinary thinking, reading, collaborative conversations, and writing

Culturally sustaining teaching is a co-requisite of academic teaching as it creates an affirming environment in which students trust that they are valued and that their learning will be cultivated. Disciplinary language exploration is a time for students to analyze and craft the language of disciplinary texts in highly interactive, discussion-based ways. This language exploration affords students the opportunity to closely examine the texts of more proficient authors and be apprenticed into their methods. To illustrate how some of these notions are enacted in KYS classrooms, we describe an interactive reading routine called Sequenced Process for Interactive Reading and Attending to Language (SPIRAL). SPIRAL is a 5-day routine involving repeated, dialogic interactions with the same complex text. Teachers use the approach in all elementary grades with students in grades 2–6 reading and discussing complex texts collaboratively with peers.

In grades K-1, students engage with complex texts through interactive teacher read alouds. In professional learning sessions, the K-1 teachers experienced SPIRAL modeled with a culturally relevant storybook, *Last Stop on Market Street* by Matt de la Peña (2015). The story is about a young boy, CJ, and his grandmother (Nana), who take a trip on the city bus through their urban neighborhood to volunteer at a soup kitchen. At the beginning of the story, CJ is upset that he has to ride the bus while his friends get to ride in a car. As the story progresses, Nana teaches CJ to appreciate the experience of riding the bus, the people they encounter, and the beauty that is all around their neighborhood.

We chose this book because it aims to communicate the importance of valuing the assets in one's community, expresses the idea that all people can work together to support and improve their communities, and illustrates the important role elders play in educating

the children in a family. The story is reflective of many KYS children's experiences. For example, KYS is located in a semi-urban, economically under-resourced neighborhood that is ethnically and linguistically diverse and brimming with rich culture and beauty. Students can recognize their own daily experiences as they interact with the book, such as the close relationships they have with their grandparents, who may live with them and care for them before and after school. When discussing the book, students make personal connections to how Nana teaches CJ, and they have much to share about the many ways their grandparents nurture them. At the same time, students can also relate to the unfairness of not having things that other children have due to economic circumstances, and these feelings can be acknowledged and validated. The book was used in all K-1 classrooms at KYS to support teachers' common understanding of the SPIRAL approach and their ability to collaborate across programs serving both Hmong-American and other culturally and linguistically diverse students.

The outline of the 5-day SPIRAL process is provided below. Each daily session lasts roughly 20–30 minutes, including time for students to write and draw in their journals each day.

- Day 1: The teacher reads the story aloud, stopping at strategic points to explain the meaning of new words or literary phrases, and invite students to discuss literal comprehension questions with a partner (e.g., *who, what, where, when*).
- Day 2: The teacher reads the story aloud a second time, this time stopping to invite students to discuss inferential questions with a partner (e.g., *How is CJ feeling? How do we know?*).
- Day 3: The teacher reads the story aloud a third time, inviting students to retell key events using language from the story, charting what students say to create an outline of the story. The students also discuss questions about the author's underlying messages, (e.g., *What do you think the author wanted us to learn from this story?*)
- Day 4: The class reviews the story outline from the previous day and uses it to jointly reconstruct the story with details, dialogue, and literary language (e.g., *the air smelled like freedom*). After this co-construction the students independently write their own versions of the story using success criteria the class generates (e.g., *I included dialogue, I used colorful language from the story*).
- Day 5: The students share their stories with partners and provide feedback, using the same success criteria from Day 4. The class then convenes to reflect about what they learned and how they grew as readers and writers throughout the week.

SPIRAL engages students in extended text-based discussions, explicitly raises their awareness about the language of literature (disciplinary language), and apprentices them to make informed register choices in order to write their own stories that meet the expectations of the genre. Teachers create additional SPIRAL lessons using culturally relevant texts that reflect their students' ethnic, cultural, linguistic, familial, and community backgrounds. In the Hmong Immersion program, students discuss similarities and differences between the structure of Hmong stories and stories in English and what counts as a good story across cultures. These types of experiences enhance students' full meaning-making potential as multilingual and multicultural people, expands their language awareness and their ability to use disciplinary language, and supports their

attainment of full proficiency in both English and Hmong, which brings social, cultural, linguistic, cognitive, and economic advantages (biliteracy development). For students learning their heritage language, biliteracy development also provides an opportunity to reclaim the language of their communities and deepen their knowledge of their cultural heritage.

Reflections & next steps

Through our researcher-practitioner partnership, we have endeavored to complicate and deepen our collective understanding of what “culturally sustaining pedagogy” means for students who are racially, ethnically, culturally, and linguistically diverse, particularly for students with recent immigrant backgrounds. We have also worked to extend our thinking about “academic language and literacy” teaching and learning so that it honors and leverages students’ assets and expands them by raising their awareness of disciplinary language and literacy, cultivating their critical stance toward texts, and apprenticing them into new ways of using language. Given persistent opportunity and achievement gaps, it is incumbent upon educators – and the researchers who partner with them – to take such a critical stance toward current pedagogical practices and the curriculum students use on a daily basis.

In future research, we are interested in finding ways to support secondary teachers in work that integrates the two principles discussed and address a notable limitation in this article, which is the omission of students’ and families’ voices. As we move forward in our partnership, student and family perspectives about the type of instruction presented here and what students gain (or don’t gain) from it will be critical for improving the work. With California’s new ethnic studies graduation requirement and expansion of multilingual programs, now is the time to challenge inequitable educational practices and systems, do things differently, to craft the kind of assets-oriented teaching that supports all students to fulfill their academic and personal potential and lead our communities toward a brighter future.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Additional resources

1. Leading with Learning: <https://leadingwithlearning.wested.org>

This website provides information about the professional learning project featured in this article and has downloadable resources.

2. Paris, D., & Alim, S. (Eds.). (2017). *Culturally sustaining pedagogies: Teaching and learning for justice in a changing world*. New York, NY: Teachers College Press.

This book explores the concept of culturally sustaining pedagogy as teaching that fosters linguistic and cultural pluralism for positive social transformation.

3. Derewianka, B., & Jones, P. (2016). *Teaching language in context*. South Melbourne, AU: Oxford University Press.

This book provides examples of how to integrate a focus on genre, register, and metalanguage in the content areas.